

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

NEW BFFs IN POLITICS

Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao** made his national ambition official when he revealed that he was working with election strategist **Prashant Kishor** to bring a *parivartan* (change) in the country and to "fill a vacuum in national politics". In the past four months, KCR has met his Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra counterparts—M.K. Stalin and Uddhav Thackeray, respectively—and may reach out to more. Will Kishor try to convince West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee—who has her own ambitions—to accept KCR as the leader of an opposition coalition? That could be tricky. The Telangana strongman is banking heavily on PK, whom he has declared his "best friend", to work his magic.

View to a Skill

Government functionaries have acknowledged that their skilling initiative has been marred by corruption and ill-focused interventions in the past years. **Rajeev Chandrasekhar**, the minister of state for electronics, IT, skill development and technology, is hard at work devising a brand new skilling policy after Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself asked him to address the issue of corruption in skilling. The minister is also keen to scale down the frequent frictions between the Union government and big tech companies. Call it skilling two birds with one stone.



THE TALE OF TWO MAURYAS





Just before the Uttar Pradesh election, **Swami Prasad Maurya** and half a dozen MLAs switched from the BJP to SP, setting the narrative of OBC anger against the saffron party. In BJP, several insiders had felt that deputy CM **Keshav Prasad Maurya** could be elevated to the CM's chair if the party fell short of a majority since he would be more acceptable to possible allies. Ironically, both Mauryas lost their seats and are now at the mercy of each party's top leadership. Keshav supporters are expecting the BJP to retain him as deputy since he is still a member of the Vidhan Parishad. Swami's followers hope the SP will field him again in a bypoll.

HINDUS & DON'TS



Saying that "it is not right to comment on the past", Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot asked people not to engage in debate over *The Kashmir Files* as it could incite communal passions. A day later, the BJP alleged that his 'anti-Hindu stand' encouraged PWD engineers to demolish the entrance gate to the Salasar Balaji temple, which has a Ram Darbar depiction on top, to widen a road. Meanwhile, interpreting Gehlot's words in their own way, the Kota administration imposed restrictions under Section 144 in the city. Following the outcry, the government is now rebuilding the gate, promising to instal idols over it and has removed references to the movie from prohibitory orders.

Unholi Dilemma

Journos in Madhya Pradesh were recently in a fix as both CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan and state party president V.D. Sharma invited them over for Holi parties on the same day. How do you attend one without offending the other? Finally, both leaders attended each other's parties. The scribes, though surprised at the lack of communication between the two top BJP leaders, didn't complain. They got to party all day.

–Kaushik Deka with Shwweta Punj, Prashant Srivastava, Rohit Parihar and Rahul Noronha